46,000+
No. of flights cancelled globally since Feb. 28. 5,500+ Indian flights cancelled

AVIATION/ TRAVEL

CHAOS IN THE SKIES

Airspace closures and war-risk costs disrupt India's busiest international routes, triggering cancellations, fare shocks and mounting financial stress for airlines

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

Delhi-based surgeon Dr Vijay S. Pandey just wanted to return home from vacation. He was in Abu Dhabi with his wife, two daughters and a relative when the airspace closed. On March 5, he booked what SpiceJet was referring to as a 'special distress flight' from Fujairah to Delhi, for the next day. Five tickets, each costing around Rs 1 lakh. The money was gone instantly from his account. No PNR was ever generated. On March 6, the flight was cancelled. As of March 22, the refund was still not in. "Paid five times the fare for the Gulf evacuation flight amid scary situation," says Pandey, now back home. "Airlines are profiting from our sufferings."

SpiceJet said since no PNR was generated, the matter was between the user and the bank. But Rs 5 lakh is a serious sum. Pandey's story—a panic booking, money deducted without a ticket, a cancellation without consequence—captures what is now the worst disruption to Indian aviation since the COVID pandemic. The government says some 426,000 Indians have returned from the Gulf since the war began on February 28. The implications for India-Gulf aviation: fares up 300-460 per cent, longer flight times and abrupt cancellations, turning a key corridor into an expensive, unpredictable route.

A wall of closed airspace stretching from the eastern Mediterranean to the Persian Gulf is the reason. Iraq, Kuwait and Syria are completely closed to civil aviation. Only limited prior-permission flights are allowed into Israel, Bahrain and Qatar. Access from the UAE narrows to a single western corridor, vulnerable to sudden overnight closures. Since Operation Sindoor in April 2025, Pakistani airspace is closed for Indian-registered aircraft. With the Middle East now fenced off as well, both westbound corridors have been snuffed out.

India-Gulf flights are adding 45-120 minutes to total time. Air India flights from Newark and New York now stop to refuel in Rome. IndiGo, which operates an all-narrowbody fleet, cancelled new long-haul routes to London, Amsterdam and Manchester after crew-duty limits were exceeded following network reshuffling. It cancelled 162 Middle East services in a single day on March 2. Its international cancellation rate has hit 75.9 per cent.

By mid-March, airfares had surged. One-way tickets from Abu Dhabi to Delhi, typically priced at Rs 10,000-21,500, were selling for Rs 39,285-69,678. On the Dubai-Delhi corridor, fares rose to Rs 50,000–60,000, with last-minute tickets even higher. On the Dubai-Kochi route—the lifeline for the 2.2-million-strong Ker-

SHOCK IN THE AIR

FUEL PRICE EXPLOSION

58.4%
Rise in global jet fuel price in a single week post Feb. 28, from $99.40 to $157.41/barrel



₹96,638
Price per kilo litre of ATF price in Delhi in March, up from Rs 83,073 in June 2025

FARE SURGE



300-460%
Fare spike on India-Gulf routes

FINANCIAL DAMAGE



₹23,500 crore
Loss suffered by Indian airlines till date in FY26

REROUTING PAIN

45-120 minutes
Extra flight time on Gulf routes

Up to 3 hours
Added time on India-Europe route via Red Sea corridor

Sources: IATA weekly monitor, industry experts